

3.2. Thesis Proposal

Once candidates have examined the relevant literature in the first year of their study, the second year of the DBA Program is devoted to the development of the Thesis Proposal (TP). The TP develops around the research question(s) previously formulated, and it speaks back the relevant literature. Consistent with the idea that during the second year candidates enter the empirical field under investigation, the TP comprises information on the research setting, methodology (quantitative and/or qualitative), and the preliminary empirical findings.

** Please note**: the detailed description of the empirical findings, including data collection and data analysis, at this stage is not compulsory, and it solely depends on the progress of each individual candidate. Candidates who have already gathered and/or analyzed the data at the stage of writing the TP, could include this information if deemed appropriate by the supervisor.

To start developing the TP, candidates are encouraged to submit to their supervisors an initial document outlining a brief summary of the research project, including the LR and the research questions(s). This document, which does not have a specific word-count, should be submitted in the first couple of months of the second year to the supervisor, and should serve as the basis of discussion.

It is essential that candidates discuss with their supervisors the contents and structure of the TP on an ongoing basis, and to follow the DBA Program' instructions below in developing their document (see section 3.4 for more specific formatting guidelines).

- **Structure:** The TP should include the following elements:
 - *Cover Page*
 - *Introduction of the Research Project, Literature Review and Research Question(s):* overview of the research question, extant literature, and gap addressed by the research project.
 - *Empirical setting:* description of the field under investigation (e.g. industry/company/occupation; the geographical area; the research sample; how and when the candidate accessed the empirical setting; the rationale behind the choice of the selected field; the candidate's familiarity with the setting under investigation and/or with the identified research participants).
 - *Methodology:* description of the methods of data collection (e.g. surveys, interviews) and data analysis (e.g. grounded theory; thematic analysis, statistical analysis), whenever these are available.

- *Empirical findings (if any)*: preliminary description and interpretation of the outcomes of data analysis. We do not expect all candidates to include this section, as availability of data may depend on the research design and progress with data collection.
- *List of references*
- *Appendices*: tables, figures, interview protocols, experimental protocols, survey instruments, and any other relevant material
- **Length**: The TP must be between 8,000 and 11,000 words (excluding the list of references and appendices)
- **Submission and deadlines**: candidates must submit the final version of the TP by the 30th of September of the second year. The TP must be uploaded as a PDF file onto the Blackboard platform within the indicated deadline above for evaluation and grading.

Please note: This is the final version of the TP, which the supervisor already approved before the final submission. As such, during the second year, candidates are encouraged to develop and submit different drafts of the TP to their supervisors, in order to receive constructive feedback to address in the new drafts of the TP.

Candidates are required to submit the final version of their TP by the date indicated above. If this deadline is not met, candidates have maximum one more year to submit the final version of the TP – i.e. 30th September of the third year. Candidates who fail in meeting this second deadline will be required to leave the DBA Program.
- **Feedback to the candidate**: Candidates will receive a qualitative grade (e.g., Very Good; see Section 3.6) by the end of November. Thesis proposals are evaluated based on the following criteria:
 - The extent to which the conceptual framework is clearly outlined;
 - The extent to which the research design is transparently and thoroughly described;
 - The extent to which the research design is appropriate for the study;
 - The extent to which the advantages and limitations of the research design are clearly discussed.

3.3. Final Thesis

During the third and final year of the DBA Program, candidates are required to write, submit, and defend their Final Thesis (dissertation). This work describes the

candidate's research project. In order for the candidate to be admitted to the DBA thesis defense (*viva voce*), the final thesis must receive a positive evaluation by the supervisor in the following areas:

- *Research question(s)*: a clear understanding of the research domain, with a clear research question that allows the problem to be managed in a rigorous way.
- *Literature review*: a thorough review of the literature in the research domain. DBA research should be based in the extant literature and hence the final thesis should adequately report the relevant literature about the management practice and place the current research reported in the thesis appropriately within that knowledge.
- *Theory*: theory development might be developed through either deductive or inductive reasoning, but it needs to be present either in a specific theory section or in the concluding part of the thesis.
- *Methodology of data collection and analysis*: DBA research must contain an empirical component where data is collected and analyzed. The DBA thesis should address the usual issues of justification of method, steps in the data collection process, method-related limitations, research quality such as validity and reliability, and ethics. The empirical component could be either quantitative or qualitative.
- *Conclusions and implications*: The research findings should be discussed within the framework of the extant literature to produce the conclusions/contributions of the research. In this way, the conclusion provides a clear link between the research problem investigated, the extant literature, and the research findings reported in the thesis. Then, implications that arise from those conclusions should be reported. Since the DBA is a degree for professionals and managers, implications for managers should have a prominent position in the final chapter of the DBA thesis, although implications for theory, policy, and further research are also relevant. Limitations should also be considered.
- *Contribution*: the thesis should show independence of thought and approach; and make an original contribution to practice and/or extending knowledge within the profession.

In the phase of writing up their final thesis, it is essential that candidates discuss with their supervisors its contents and structure on an ongoing basis, and to follow the DBA Program' instructions below in developing their work (see section 3.4 for specific formatting guidelines).

- **Structure:** The final thesis should include the following elements:
 - Cover page.
 - Dedication (not mandatory)
 - Abstract (350 words)
 - Acknowledgments (not mandatory)
 - Table of contents
 - List of figures, tables, abbreviations
 - Introduction
 - Literature Review
 - Research Setting
 - Methodology
 - Empirical Findings
 - Discussion
 - Conclusions
 - List of references
 - Appendices
- **Length:** The length of the final thesis may vary depending on the topic, methods, as well as individual preferences of the candidates and their supervisors. In the past, a typical final thesis, formatted according to the guidelines below (section 3.4.), ranged between 70 and 100 pages. However, we understand that not all dissertations should conform to this typical length – which is hence not a formal requirement.
- **Submission and deadlines:** Candidates are requested to submit the final thesis in PDF format via email to both their supervisor and the DBA Program Manager. The submission of the final thesis must occur by the 23rd of November of the third year.
****Please note**:** This is the final version of the thesis, which can no longer be edited and modified – i.e. it means that the supervisor already read and agreed on the final version of the thesis, and the candidate has already addressed all the feedback previously provided by the supervisor. As such, during the final year, candidates are encouraged to develop and submit to their supervisor different drafts of the final thesis, in order receive constructive feedback to address in the new drafts of the final thesis.
- **Feedback to the candidate:** Candidates will receive a qualitative grade (e.g., Very Good; see Section 3.6) by mid December. Final theses are evaluated based on the following criteria:
 - The extent to which the thesis shows a clear understanding of the research domain with a clear research question that allows a rigorous investigation;

- The extent to which the empirical component of the thesis is transparently presented, appropriately justified, and rigorously executed;
 - The extent to which the thesis makes an original contribution to research;
 - The extent to which the thesis makes an original contribution to practice.
- **Admission to thesis defense:** If by the 30th of November of the third year the supervisor accepts the final version of the thesis, the candidate is invited to defend the final thesis in *viva voce* in front of the DBA Board. The DBA Board comprises the President (DBA Director) and all the supervisors of the candidates who have been admitted to the defense of their thesis. The DBA Board is approved by the Dean of SDA Bocconi School of Management.

If by the 23rd of November of the third year, the supervisor does not accept the final version of the thesis, the candidate can choose between option (a) and option (b):

- Option (a) – *Extension*: The candidate can choose to defer the submission of one year to improve the DBA research project. Please refer to Section 7 in this document to learn on how to apply for the extension.
- Option (b) – *Direct submission to the DBA Board*: The candidate can request to submit the final thesis directly to the DBA Board. The DBA Board may provide either a positive or a negative evaluation of the final dissertation:
 - Positive evaluation: The candidate is invited to defend the thesis in *viva voce* in front of the DBA Board.
 - Negative evaluation: The candidate is dismissed from the DBA Program.

Candidates who have been invited to defend the final thesis in person in front of the DBA Board, will be participating to the thesis defense and graduation ceremony, which will take place on SDA Bocconi main campus in the month of January of the following year.

3.4. Formatting guidelines

Candidates are required to follow the formatting requirements below when preparing the submissions of the three deliverables – i.e. LR, TP and Final Thesis.

- *Paper size*: cm 29X21 (A4).
- *Font, size, line spacing and margins*: candidates are asked to choose and consistently use one of the following fonts: Arial, Tahoma, Times New Roman, or Verdana. The size of characters must be 12. The line spacing must be “double”. Margins must be 2.5 cm (right, left, above, and below).

- *Cover page*: the cover page must be written using the same font employed in the main body of the output, and it must include the title of the output, the name of the DBA candidate, the name of the supervisor, the date, and the exact word-count (including list of references; excluding tables, figures, appendices, and other relevant documents). Candidates are asked to download the cover page for the LR and the TP inside the Blackboard Platform, within the folder “Courses-Literature Review/Dissertation Proposal”. For the Final Thesis, candidates receive the cover page via email from the Program Manager.
- *Table of contents*: in the table of contents candidates outline the structure of the deliverable and provide the page numbers associated to all chapters and sub-chapters.
- *Statement regarding the use of AI*: in this statement candidates disclose the gen AI tools used in the production of the deliverable. An example of such statement would be: “During production of this work, the author(s) utilized generative artificial intelligence, namely [LIST TOOLS]. These tools were used to [DESCRIBE WHERE, HOW, AND WHY]. The author(s) reviewed all content and assert the content within this document is factually accurate and free of plagiarism. The author(s) take full responsibility for the submitted document.”
- *List of references*: In the process of developing the DBA deliverables (LR, TP and Final Thesis), candidates are asked to build up their list of references – i.e. the bibliography. This can be done either manually, or by employing an *ad hoc* software (e.g. Mendeley). Please make sure the APA style is employed consistently, as per the following example:
 - Alvesson, M., & Willmott, H. (2002). Identity regulation as organizational control: Producing the appropriate individual. *Journal of Management Studies*, 39(5), 619-644.
- *Footnotes and endnotes*: The DBA Program at SDA Bocconi does not encourage the use of footnotes and/or endnotes. However, there might be situations where footnotes are needed. Please do not use endnotes.
- *Interview guidelines, questionnaires, and other important documents*: Should candidates have any research questionnaire, interview guidelines, and/or other empirical material employed in the fieldwork (e.g. company documents, pictures), they must include them in their final output. Depending on the type of material, documents should be added either in the main body of the deliverable (e.g. pictures, figures, charts) or as an appendix (e.g. interview guidelines, questionnaires). Candidates can discuss this with their supervisors.

- *In-text citations*: to cite the work of other authors and scholars in the main body of your work, candidates must use the following APA style consistently throughout the document:
 - When you are directly quoting one author: (Alvesson, 1994, p. 87)
 - When you are directly quoting two authors: (Alvesson & Willmott, 2002, p. 32)
 - When you are directly quoting three or more authors: (Alvesson et al., 2002, p. 32)
 - When you are paraphrasing one, two or three+ authors, and/or referring generally to their work: (Alvesson, 1994); (Alvesson & Willmott, 2002); (Alvesson et al., 2002)
- *Numbering of pages*: The pages of the DBA deliverables should be numbered. The cover page is excluded from numeration. Candidates must use the Roman system (e.g. i, ii, iii) for the pages containing dedication, abstract, acknowledgements, table of contents, and statement regarding the use of AI. Candidates must use the Arabic system (e.g. 1, 2, 3) for all other pages.

3.5. Ethics guidelines

Prior to start their empirical inquiry, candidates are required to discuss with their supervisors the Ethics procedures in place at SDA Bocconi School of Management. This is particularly relevant if candidates are conducting research that involves human subjects (i.e., interviews, experiments, survey, etc.) and need to complete the “Consent Form”. Candidates can login with their Bocconi credentials using the following link: <https://ecr.unibocconi.it/>

From the portal, candidates can download the user manual. All the information on the Bocconi Ethics Committee, Bocconi Ethics Policy, the documents on Ethics in Research at the European and international level, as well as the direct access to the Portal, are available on the Intranet Page of the Research Division: <https://blife.unibocconi.it/web/divisione-faculty-e-ricerca/ethics>. For any questions/suggestions, please contact ethics@unibocconi.it

3.6. Grading and evaluation

The Literature Review (LR), Thesis Proposal (TP), and Final Thesis (FT) are graded according to the scale below (Figure 3). The final grade is expressed only qualitatively (e.g. very good).

Figure 3: Grading scale of LR, TP and FT

Final Grade			Italian Scale		Equivalent out of 30
	Excellent	E	Eccellente	E	29-30
	Very Good	VG	Buono	B	25-28
	Good	G	Soddisfacente	S	21-24
	Satisfactory	S	Appena soddisfacente	AS	18-20
	Unsatisfactory	F	Insufficiente	I	< 18

During the Thesis Defense, the Faculty Board assigns a maximum of 6 points to the candidate, on the basis of the Thesis Defense and a General Assessment of the participant's performance. The Final DBA Grade is hence expressed according to the scale below (Figure 4).

Figure 4: Grading scale for the Final DBA Grade included in the transcript

Final Grade			Italian Scale		Equivalent out of 110
	Excellent	E	Eccellente	E	106-110 L
	Very Good	VG	Buono	B	92-105
	Good	G	Soddisfacente	S	77-91
	Satisfactory	S	Appena soddisfacente	AS	66-76

4. Thesis defense

The candidates defend their DBA thesis in *viva voce* in front of the DBA Board in the month of January. The Board is formed by the President (DBA Director), as well as the DBA supervisors of the candidates defending their thesis.

Candidates will be notified by the DBA Program Manager via email by mid-December of the date and time of their thesis defense. Each candidate is permitted to invite up to three guests to attend.

The day of the thesis defense, candidates are asked to gather in the waiting-room before being invited by the DBA Board to present and defend their DBA research project. The room numbers will be communicated to the candidates via email approximately a week before the presentation by the DBA Program Manager.

The defense lasts approximately 40 minutes, which includes 30 minutes of presentation by the candidate and 10 minutes of questions from the DBA Board. However, questions to the candidate from the DBA Board could be also addressed during the candidate's presentation. The defense must be supported using Power Point slides (these must be sent to the Program Manager 15 days before the discussion). After the discussion, the candidate is asked to leave the discussion room and reach the waiting-room. In the meantime, the DBA Board deliberates the final grade. This process lasts approximately 10 minutes. The candidate is therefore invited to join the Board for the proclamation.

5. DBA graduation

Candidates will be notified of the date of the graduation ceremony by the DBA Program Manager via email approximately six months before the ceremony. Each candidate may invite up to three guests. Candidates who wish to invite more than three guests may coordinate with classmates who are inviting fewer guests and arrange a possible reallocation of guest places.

During the graduation ceremony, candidates are individually proclaimed "Doctor of Business Administration". The graduation ceremony takes place at SDA Bocconi School of Management in Milan. Prior to starting the ceremony, candidates are invited to arrive at SDA Bocconi School of Management 90 minutes before the start of the ceremony and reach the room where they will be robed with the gowns and caps. Whilst these are provided by the School, candidates will take the gowns and caps with them as a gift by SDA Bocconi.

Detailed information about the graduation ceremony will be sent to candidates by the DBA Program Manager via email closer to the event.

6. Tuition fees and payments

All the information about tuition fees and payments can be found in Blackboard, under “Program”. Any question about tuition fees and payments can be addressed to the Administration (see section 9).

7. Temporary suspension, extension, and withdraw from the Program

When needed, during the 3-year DBA Program candidates are allowed to apply for either a temporary suspension of their study, or an extension. Please read carefully the information below detailing each option.

- **Temporary suspension (Stop & Go):** During the DBA Program, whenever candidates find themselves in time of predicament, they may consider to apply for a temporary suspension (Stop & Go). This can be done by sending an official email to the DBA Director, who may authorize it only for exceptional reasons that are deemed duly justified, and if the candidate is compliant with due payment of fees. If the Stop & Go is granted, the candidate must complete the DBA Program within the terms of the DBA edition in which the candidate is re-admitted, without undergoing a new selection process. An integration fee is to be paid, which corresponds to the increase in tuition fee for the new edition.

In case of Stop & Go, the candidate's position will be frozen and IT systems suspended, the key deliverables of the DBA Program prior to the suspension date will be recognized in the next edition. The candidate will attend all the courses and activities not taken in the previous edition and is required to submit all the DBA deliverables.

Further information about the Stop & Go, can be found in the document “Doctorate in Business Administration - Rules”, which is signed by the candidate when admitted to the DBA Program.

- **Extension:** Candidates can also ask for a one-year extension by sending an official email to the DBA Director. The extension can only be considered at the end of the third and final year of the DBA Program, when the candidate and the supervisor consider to be challenging to submit and defend the thesis at this point.

The request for an extension can be made each year after the third year, for a maximum of two consecutive years. If by the end of the second-year extension the candidate fails in completing, submitting, and defending the final thesis, the candidate is asked to leave the DBA Program. Please note that as per the General Conditions sub-signed at the time of the enrolment, each additional year will incur a nominal fee of 12.000 EUR.

- **Withdrawal:** Candidates who wish to withdraw from the DBA Program must communicate their decision by emailing the DBA Director.

In case of either temporary suspension (Stop & Go) or withdrawal, SDA Bocconi has the right to withhold the instalments already paid by the candidate. Moreover, the candidate shall pay the instalments that have become due at the date of temporary suspension or withdrawal.

Any information about extension, temporary suspension, and withdrawal can be addressed to the DBA Director.

8. Working spaces

DBA candidates' workspaces are both physical and digital. The residential modules are held in presence at SDA Bocconi School of Management Campus, Via Sarfatti 10 (Milan). The dedicated room number is communicated by the Program Manager via email prior to the start of the modules.

The virtual modules are held onto the Blackboard platform. The invitation links to attend the virtual classes are shared by the Program Manager via email prior the start of the modules.

Candidates are welcome to access the SDA Bocconi Campus even outside the scheduled residential modules, to work on their projects. Access to the Campus is possible either via the QR code available on the SDAB Life App, or via the badge candidates have received at the beginning of the Program.

Candidates can use only the "study box" spaces, which can be reserved via the SDAB Life App by following this procedure: from the Home Page, access the Bocconi Urban Campus tab, click on the "Reservation" tab, and then add a reservation by clicking onto the + icon (bottom right).

9. Key people

The DBA Program at SDA Bocconi School of Management comprises different

professional figures, who are part of the faculty and staff. Each of them is assigned with specific responsibilities inside the Program.

- **DBA Director**, Giada Di Stefano: giada.distefano@unibocconi.it
Prof. Giada Di Stefano is the Director of the DBA Program. She is the point of reference to candidates and supervisors for any academic aspect. She chairs the selection committee of the Program, facilitates the matching of candidates to supervisors, and approves any request for suspensions and extensions.
- **DBA Program Manager**, Ulyana Sapozhnikava: ulyana.sapozhnikava@sdabocconi.it
Ulyana Sapozhnikava is the Program Manager of the DBA Program. She is the point of reference to candidate and supervisors for any logistical and technical issue.
- **Admission & Recruitment**, Lorenzo Starita: admissions.dba@sdabocconi.it
Lorenzo Starita is the Admission Officer of the DBA Program. He is the point of reference to prospect candidates.
- **Admin**, Sabrina Libanore sabrina.libanore@sdabocconi.it
Sabrina Libanore is the Administrative Officer of the DBA Program. She is the point of reference to request information on fees and payments.